
Civil society, colonial constraints, 1885–1919

The decades that spanned the turn of the twentieth century marked the apogee of the British imperial system, whose institutional framework had been set after 1857. At the same time, these decades were marked by a rich profusion and elaboration of voluntary organizations; a surge in publication of newspapers, pamphlets and posters; and the writing of fiction and poetry as well as political, philosophical, and historical non-fiction. With this activity, a new level of public life emerged, ranging from meetings and processions to politicized street theatre, riots, and terrorism. The vernacular languages, patronized by the government, took new shape as they were used for new purposes, and they became more sharply distinguished by the development of standardized norms. The new social solidarities forged by these activities, the institutional experience they provided, and the redefinitions of cultural values they embodied were all formative for the remainder of the colonial era, and beyond.

Yet it was only to be in the 1920s that the British began to recognize the hollowness of their long-held assumption that self-rule for India would be pushed off into an indefinite future. The viceroys who presided over the final decades of the century – Dufferin (1884–8), Lansdowne (1888–94), and Elgin (1894–9) – were, in Percival Spear’s phrase, ‘imperial handymen’ all. Unshaken by the fissures revealed in the Ilbert Bill controversy and imagining a future like the past, they endeavoured to secure the economic interests of empire, establish secure borders, and provide a government of limited responsibilities. Curzon, as viceroy from 1899 to 1905, by his

driven brilliance in seeking those very same ends, precipitated a public furor that energized the till then quiescent Indian National Congress, which was to lead India to independence. The succeeding decade was one of public action and government response, including, under Minto as viceroy (1906–10), a modest expansion of Indian participation in governing councils. Through the First World War, however, the Indian role in governing was limited to providing manpower almost exclusively at the lower levels of government, to service in the army, and to consultation on the part of loyal elites. This continuity with the earlier colonial period sat uneasily on a society experiencing change in every dimension of social, political, and cultural life, while increasingly convinced that imperial rule did not further India's interests.

A GLOBAL IMPERIAL SYSTEM

Dadabhai Naoroji (1825–1917), later to be remembered as the ‘Grand Old Man of Indian Nationalism’, a graduate of Elphinstone College, Bombay, was a mathematician who for half a century argued for the rights of Indians as British subjects. He was the first Indian elected to the British House of Commons, where from 1892 to 1895 he set out India's interests with his characteristic clarity of vision and elegant prose. He expressed with eloquence the values of several generations of elite Indians, as they engaged in a shared language with their colonial rulers over the question of their country's governance, as the following excerpt shows:

In this Memorandum I desire to submit for the kind and generous consideration of His Lordship the Secretary of State for India, that from the same cause of the deplorable drain [of economic wealth from India to England], besides the material exhaustion of India, the moral loss to her is no less sad and lamentable... All [the Europeans] effectually do is to eat the substance of India, material and moral, while living there, and when they go, they carry away all they have acquired... The thousands [of Indians] that are being sent out by the universities every year find themselves in a most anomalous position. There is no place for them in their motherland... What must be the inevitable consequence?... despotism and destruction... or destroying hand and power.

Naoroji judged British claims of ‘govern[ing] India for India's good’ nothing more than ‘purest romance’. In ‘the drain’, he

identified a critical component of an economic system that fundamentally secured Britain's economic position in the larger world. Each year, funds were transferred to England to liquidate the old Company shares; to pay off debt on secure and profitable capital investments (notably those for the railways); and to provide funds for the operation of the India Office, the purchase of stores for India, and for pensions. That burden, Naoroji argued, contributed to the often oppressive taxation demanded of the peasantry. It was dramatically enhanced when the value of silver (the standard on which the rupee was based) declined against the pound sterling, in which payments had to be made, at the end of the century. Defenders claimed these transfers were fair value for services provided; others, including a handful of British critics, saw it as taking away resources that otherwise would have been used for internal investment within India. The favourable balance of trade with India, to which the revenue flow contributed, enabled Britain to meet its trading deficit with other nations. The issue was a persistent goad to Indian political aspirations.

By 1913 India had become the chief export market for British goods, including textiles, iron and steel goods, machinery, and other products reflecting Britain's industrial strength. India, in return, supplied Britain with critically needed raw materials including cotton, indigo, jute, rice, oil seeds, and tea. By the end of the nineteenth century, India's commercial agriculture tied it to markets and forces beyond its borders in ways that affected the economy as a whole and the lives of millions dependent on it. Far from moving away from an agricultural towards an industrial base in these decades, in all probability the proportion of those dependent on agriculture grew slightly to over 70 per cent. The vicissitudes of dependence on export crops is nowhere clearer than in the case of cotton, whose exports to Britain increased in value almost three times between the mid-1850s and the mid-1870s (because of the American Civil War), only to drop to about a ninth of that level by 1900. Indigo virtually disappeared as an export crop by World War One, as synthetic dyes replaced it, while jute and tea emerged as major cash crops in those same years. The latter were dominated by British business interests, who benefited from favourable arrangements for land and capital. Commercial agriculture, though it provided income to

peasant growers, in many areas drove out the sturdy, low-quality grains that had provided staple foods, and in so doing made peasants dependent on food grown elsewhere. One success story was the large-scale development of 'canal colonies' in the Punjab, where assured water on newly cultivated soils made possible a vast expansion in the output of wheat, sugar cane, and maize. Commercial cropping characterized an increasing proportion of production for internal consumption as well as the export market.

Commercial agriculture was made possible by the transportation infrastructure provided above all by the railway. By the end of the century India possessed the fifth longest railway system in the world. The pre-eminence of British export interests was clear in a layout that focused on routes to the ports and a rate structure that disadvantaged inland transport. Bombay's neo-Gothic Victoria Terminus, completed in 1887, a popular subject for painting and photography (plate 5.1), was architecturally similar to railway terminals in London and Melbourne, and so made visible India's central position in the larger imperial system. The rail lines also, however, made possible the beginnings of Indian-owned industry. This was associated in particular with two families, the Tatas and the Birlas, both based in areas of India where British business interests were less developed than in the east. In 1877 the Parsi Jamsetji Tata founded the Empress Mills in Nagpur, followed by other mills in Bombay and Ahmedabad, and in 1907 he added Tata Iron and Steel in Bihar. The Birlas, of the Marwari clan originating in Rajasthan but active by the end of the century in trading across the north, similarly moved into textiles and steel during World War One. Both families succeeded by developing products that did not compete with British manufactures, for example in low-count cotton and in yarn for the China market.

The value of India to Britain extended beyond these direct economic advantages. India served at the turn of the century as the centre itself of many aspects of Britain's global imperial system. One of the most important was as a source of indentured labour for Britain's tropical colonies. Indenture had begun as a way to replace black labour in the cane fields after the abolition of slavery in the late 1830s, but it increased with the growing British demand for sugar. Confronted with land fragmentation and agricultural



3. Victoria Terminus, finest R.R. station in Asia, Bombay, India. Copyright, 1908, by Stereo-Travel Co.

Plate 5.1 Great Indian Peninsular Railway Terminus (Victoria Terminus), Bombay. The structure joins an exuberant Venetian Gothic design with Indian ornament and detail by the Indian students of Lockwood Kipling, the poet's father.

uncertainty from the 1870s, Indian villagers proved increasingly willing to accept a period of overseas labour. Indentured Indians went to Jamaica and Trinidad, British Guiana, Mauritius and Fiji, Natal, and Malaya. Others went to Burma, Ceylon, and along the East African coast of Kenya, Zanzibar, and Uganda. [Plate 5.2](#) shows Indian workers in the 1890s building the railway that made possible development of the new British possessions in East Africa. Between 1911 and 1920, however, indenture was brought to an end in each



Map 3 The British Indian Empire, c. 1900.

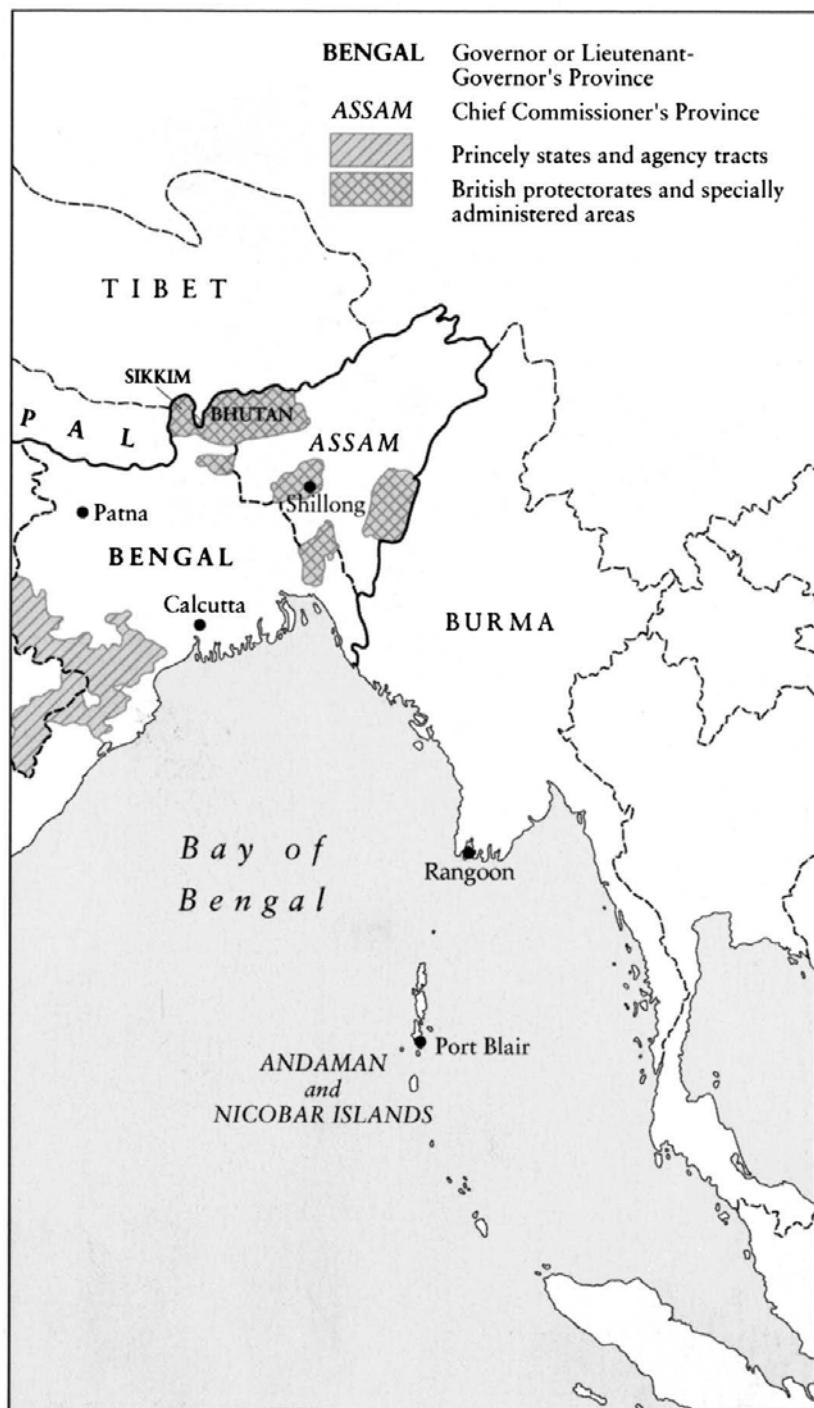




Plate 5.2 Indian workers on the Uganda railway, c. 1898. Sikhs and other Punjabis were recruited for the construction of this railway line in Britain's new East African colony.

of these areas as voices were raised in protest at its continuance. Among these were the viceroy Lord Hardinge (1911-16) as well as nationalists, including Madan Mohan Malaviya (1861-1946), the founder of Banaras Hindu University (1916). Nationalists found in this overseas migration both a heightened image of imperial exploitation that brought shame to India, and, at the same time, as Indians took up residence around the globe, a vision of 'Greater India', a nation beyond its borders, that recalled images of ancient glory. Engagement with the plight of diaspora Indians, as we shall see with Gandhi, was a critical stimulus to Indian nationalism.

The Indian Army, in similar fashion, was deployed, at the cost of the Indian tax-payer, to protect trade routes and secure imperial interests from China, most notably during the 1900 Boxer rebellion, to East Africa, and to the Middle East. British officials themselves, along with Indian police and secretarial staff, especially technical personnel in such areas as forestry and public works, whose skills were honed in India, found employment in other areas of the Empire. Indigenous Indian trading groups also expanded their operations into British colonies around the Indian Ocean. Among these were the Muslim Ismaili community who followed the Aga Khan, with trading networks particularly in East Africa, and the Madras-based Nattukottai Chettiars, whose control of credit was indispensable to the development of commercial agriculture in British Burma and Ceylon. There were, finally, benefits to Britain from its possession of India that defy measurement, such as its role in enhancing national pride and, in generating that shared emotion, masking Britain's own hierarchies of gender and class. In 1900 Curzon said, 'We could lose all our [white settlement] dominions and still survive, but if we lost India, our sun would sink to its setting.'

NEW CLASSES, NEW COLLABORATORS

In Kipling's literary masterpiece *Kim* (1901), India is populated by a congeries of distinct, often colourful groups, each with its presumably unchanging characteristics. The central figure, Kim, is an orphaned child depicted as a chameleon, able to put on any identity, but who must, as the novel unfolds, emerge to be the Briton he truly is. As Kim travels the Grand Trunk Road, moreover, he enacts the



Plate 5.3 Rudyard Kipling stories published in cheap editions as part of the Indian Railway Library series.

British colonial fantasy of the omniscient observer, alone able to know all who inhabit the land:

They met a troop of long-haired, strong-scented Sansis with baskets of lizards and other unclean food on their backs . . . moving at a quick, furtive jog-trot, and all other castes gave them ample room; for the Sansi is deep pollution. Behind them, walking wide and stiffly across the strong shadows, the memory of his leg-irons still on him, strode one newly released from the jail; his full stomach and shiny skin to prove that the Government fed its prisoners better than most honest men could feed themselves. Kim knew that walk well, and made broad jest of it as they passed. Then an Akali, a wild-eyed, wild haired Sikh devotee in the blue-checked clothes of his faith, with polished-steel quoits glistening on the cone of his tall blue turban, stalked past, returning from a visit to one of the independent Sikh States, where he had been singing the ancient glories of the Khalsa to College-trained princelings in top-boots and white-cord breeches. Kim was careful not to irritate that man; for the Akali's temper is short and his arm quick.

In Kim's India, and that of predominant British opinion, the land is peopled by the humble folk of the road, and those who work with the British to sustain the Raj. The latter are represented in the novel by two of Kim's protectors. One is Muslim, the tough horse trader of the frontier, Mahbub Ali; the other is Hindu, the educated Bengali Hurree Babu. Such English-language novels, readily available in inexpensive editions (plate 5.3), set in place, for the British and elite Indians alike, an enduring view of Indian society.

Opportunities for Indians to participate in the governing structure of empire were strongly shaped by the theories that had emerged after the 1857 revolt of an unchanging social order comprised of a mosaic of separate communities, whose 'natural leaders' spoke for them. Although by the final decades of the century some British and some Indians espoused the liberal theory of societies comprised of individuals, free to make choices and, ultimately, free to vote, the 'darbar' view of Indian governance, with 'consultation' as its primary strategy, prevailed. The princes and landed classes continued in place as a conservative bulwark of power, while new colleges were established to socialize heirs into a set of pseudo-aristocratic colonial values, from polo and tiger shooting to lavish entertainments.

Agricultural society continued to be marked by fragmentation of plots, hierarchies of tenants and, nurtured by a high and often inflexible cash revenue demand, classes of moneylenders whose advances

secured high rates of return. Agricultural practices that appear from a distant perspective economically wasteful were at the time rational for the owners of land, for a secure rental income was more valuable than the uncertain returns from investing in new seeds or machinery. The tenancy laws passed in this period, furthermore, froze the pattern of smallholdings and worked on the whole to strengthen classes of rich peasants like the Bengal jotedars, who came to see their interests tied to the stability of the landed regime. Most importantly, the Punjab Land Alienation Act of 1901 prohibited the sale of agricultural property to 'non-agricultural' classes. The aim of the act was to protect debt-ridden tenants, but in fact it simultaneously strengthened landlord and Muslim interests against the urban Hindu trading and moneylending classes who had increasingly been investing in land. The Act is a reminder that the regime's theoretical commitment to *laissez-faire* and rational economics could easily be overridden by political considerations.

The Muslim leadership was cultivated as a potential bulwark of stability. British fears of an imagined threat from worldwide Muslim conspiracy in the later nineteenth century could presumably be countered by encouraging India's sturdy monotheists and former rulers. The Sikhs, too, in their case nowhere more than in the army, were encouraged to distinguish themselves from the larger society and see their interests best served by outspoken loyalty. Such loyalties could not be taken for granted. Muslims in the United Provinces, for example, were stunned by the decision in 1900 to make Hindi equal with Urdu as the language of the lower courts and administration, a decision explicitly understood by Sir Antony MacDonnell, the lieutenant governor, as a way to balance Hindus against Muslims. Urdu, with a larger admixture of Persian loan words and written in an Indo-Persian script, and Hindi, drawing more on Sanskrit loan words and written in the Sanskrit-based Devanagari script, were linguistically the same language. Although Urdu had been the *lingua franca* across north India since the eighteenth century and was known generally by the urban-educated, Bharatendu Harischandra of Banaras and others espoused the cause of Hindi as part of their cultural and nationalist activities. On the whole, however, Muslim spokesmen in these years, like minorities in many colonial areas, saw their interests best served by identification with the existing regime.

The Western-educated class represented an increasingly audible voice in public life. The formally educated were few in number, barely 3 per cent of the total population in 1921 (in a ratio of roughly 5 males for every 1 female), with resources continuing to be focused at the university level. The English-educated comprised less than 1 per cent of the population. For those with university education, as Naoroji's words above recalled, government employment was a major goal. With strong structural constraints operating against Indian participation in the modern business sector, government service, along with the modern professions of law, medicine, education, and journalism, were the preferred routes to employment. Still, despite their mastery of the English language, by the mid-1880s no more than a dozen Indians had succeeded in passing the examinations and entering the Indian Civil Service.

As their numbers grew, educated Indians were increasingly accommodated within the governing structure. The Municipals Council Act of 1882 had given responsibility for such areas as education, sanitation, and public health to local bodies, along with the right to levy – and be blamed for – local taxes. The Indian Councils Act of 1892 introduced the principle of limited election for legislative councils and opened up the provincial councils to discussion of the annual budget. One of the foremost early nationalists, Gopal Krishna Gokhale (1866-1915), humane and articulate professor of English literature, mathematics, and political economy, served, for example, on the Poona Municipal Council, the Bombay Legislative Council, and, finally, the Imperial Legislative Council (1902-15). There he spoke critically and creatively in the interests of good government – including the need for universal education, greater representation of Indians in government, and increased employment opportunities.

The limited public role open to educated Indians at the end of the century was a subject not only for political discussion but for literary comment. Notable were the biting Urdu couplets of the sub-judge Akbar Allahabadi (1846-1921) and the ironic Bengali writing of the deputy magistrate Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay (1838-94). Their own experience of restricted professional opportunity, evident in their relatively low civil service positions, fuelled a mockery of sycophantic loyalism. Akbar, for instance, reminded the loyalist

Muslims of Aligarh of the few crumbs held out to them by their rulers:

If fifty to a hundred get good posts, what of it?
No nation yet was ever based – on fifty to a hundred.

In 1885 some seventy English-educated Indians came together in Bombay to form the Indian National Congress. The focus of the longest-lived nationalist movement in the modern colonial world, the Congress was the model for nationalist movements elsewhere, above all in South Africa, and a force for stability in the early years of Indian independence. The catalyst for the foundation of the Congress was a retired British ICS officer, Allen Octavian Hume (1829–1912), who had spoken for nationalist interests during the furor over the Ilbert Bill. The key to the Congress's initial cohesion, however, were the shared interests and common experiences of a cohort of Indians from across the country, many of whom had shared formative experiences in London while studying for the bar or the civil service. They were participants in the rapidly expanding communications network of their day in India: the railroads, mentioned above; the postal system, with a three – to fourfold increase in use by the end of the century; and newspapers, whose number in English approximately doubled to about 300 between 1885 and 1905, while the number of vernacular newspapers increased even more.

Many Congress members had participated earlier in more local organizations that sought to represent the interests of Indians to the government. Among these were the early Triplicane Literary Society (1868) and the later Mahajana Sabha (1894) of Madras. Surendranath Banerjea (1848–1926), a brilliant student who struggled to enter the ICS and was then dismissed on petty grounds, founded the Indian Association in Calcutta in 1876. Other comparable groups included the Allahabad People's Association (1885), the Indian Association of Lahore (1877), the Poona Sarvajanik Sabha (1867) and the Deccan Education Society (1884), the National Mohammedan Association (in Calcutta), and the Bombay Presidency Association (1885).

The organizers of the Congress made explicit efforts to draw Muslims into their meetings. Hume, for instance, invited Badr al-din Tyabji (1844–1906), a Bombay lawyer and leader of the Shi'a

Bohras, to preside over the Madras Congress of 1887. Most Muslim leaders, however, like Sayyid Ahmad Khan, Sayyid Amir‘Ali (1849–1928), the brilliant lawyer and religious thinker of Calcutta, and others, argued that Congress could not be the spokesman for the interests of the two distinct ‘communities’ that comprised India. Sayyid Ahmad repeated over and over that ‘India is like a bride which has got two beautiful and lustrous eyes – Hindus and Mussalmans.’ Representative government on the British pattern, he insisted, was ill-suited to such a land. Even Tyabji, despite his commitment to a common platform with non-Muslims in the Congress, nevertheless shared the pervasive opinion that identity rested in one’s religious community.

The Congress vision, by contrast, insisted that interests of self, caste, and community be subordinated to the ‘public good’ and the Indian nation. In its early years, the Congress, like Sayyid Ahmad Khan, did not question the continuance of British rule. Its members largely represented the professions of law, journalism, and teaching; a small number were businessmen; some few were landowners and merchants. They wanted more Indian participation in the legislative councils, and a genuine opening of the ICS to Indians by raising the age limit for the competitive examinations and holding them simultaneously in India. They advocated less expenditure on the army, an outlay that could reach half of all Indian revenues in these years and a timely concern in the 1880s with troops deployed to Burma. The early Congress operated through petitions and addresses as a ‘loyal opposition’. In its first twenty years, Congress gave little evidence of what would be its future importance. As an organization, eschewing all matters of religious controversy and social reform, it deliberately stood aside from the intense and widespread social cultural reform activities of the day.

VOLUNTARY ASSOCIATIONS, RELIGIOUS MOVEMENTS, AND TRADITIONALIST INSTITUTIONS

An extraordinary efflorescence of new associations, together with such activities as a new popular theatre and the revival of martial traditions, changed public life, as well as the everyday life of many segments of the population, during these years. These new activities

must be seen against a backdrop of far-reaching social change. New markets, new communications, and new networks linked individuals to larger arenas, and brought former strangers into new settings that stimulated new styles of social interaction. Although the urban share of India's population remained fairly constant in this period, with no more than 10 per cent living in settlements larger than 5,000, individual cities, not least the three presidency capitals, grew substantially, and a town could virtually disappear or, should it, for example, fall on a new railway line, double in size. Such changes as the spread of commercial agriculture brought prosperity to some in the rural areas as well. For all, new socioreligious organizations provided routes to community, to status, and to new conceptions of self-worth.

The decennial census, begun in 1881, provided an important stimulus for the recognition of group status. Many castes, or emerging castes, as they aspired to higher status in the census listings, formed associations, typically called *sabhas*. Members would agree to a range of socially preferred behaviour, often focused on such issues as control of womenfolk (by greater seclusion or modest dress); in some cases they adopted vegetarianism or abstinence from liquor; sometimes they sought Brahman ritual services. A small but striking example of this process illustrates not only the extent of cultural change but also how relatively obscure and humble groups could take advantage of the census enumeration. In this case a group in Punjab called Mahtons sought to be recorded in the census of 1911 as high-status Rajputs based on their history and behaviour. The district census officer, on the basis of an earlier government survey, identified them as former hunters and scavengers turned agriculturalists, but noted that the Rajput Pratnik Sabha of the Punjab and Kashmir recognized them as Rajputs. If this recognition were accepted in the census, the group would then be eligible for army recruitment and a Punjab government zamindari scholarship. Such negotiations over status spread across India during these decades. 'Castes' increasingly established relations over larger areas and were more formalized in their membership and identity. To the extent that they published journals, submitted petitions, and opted for a formal organization, they were part of the widespread movement towards modern organizational forms characteristic of this period.

The ‘caste system’, far from unchanging, in this period took on new forms.

Complementing this ‘grass-roots’ cultural change was the patronage of religious and cultural life provided by the princes, landlords, and business and trading classes. The role played by these classes is critical to an understanding of cultural and social life in India’s colonial society. Prosperous families and individuals gained legitimacy in the eyes of both the rulers and the common people through their patronage of performances, rituals, and cultural or religious organizations. For princes and landlords, patronage, and the accompanying ritual observances, offered an opportunity to build a base of support when they were largely excluded from formal politics. The Rajas of Banaras, for example, like the Maharajas of Mysore, by their patronage of the splendid annual re-enactment of the Ramayana epic, made its symbols central to the community identity of the merchant and banking elites who contributed to its support, as well as of the specialists, performers, and viewers who participated. Princes and landlords were also key to the encouragement of art music and indigenous medicine, above all by establishing modern schools that supported, for example, both ayurveda, a medical system based in the Sanskritic tradition, and yunani tibb, the Graeco-Arabic medical tradition, the latter of which had virtually disappeared outside India by the twentieth century.

The organizations formed during these years encompassed a variety of activities. Indeed, it is difficult to categorize them in any simple way as ‘religious’, ‘social’, or ‘political’ in their goals. As the example of caste sabhas makes plain, a given organization might at once seek to modify practices of worship and ritual; foster changed styles of dress, diet, and sociality among its members; and call on government bodies for certain kinds of action. Whatever the focus, associations found the opportunities afforded by the inexpensive lithographic presses indispensable. A photograph from Amritsar, for example, shows Sikh booksellers marketing pamphlets and reproductions of sacred subjects to the ever-growing number of pilgrims visiting this sacred city (plate 5.4).

Many reform societies, like the Brahmo Samaj founded in Bengal a half-century earlier, adopted an ethic of individual and collective ‘improvement’. In 1887, Mahadev Govind Ranade (1842–1901),



Plate 5.4 Booksellers, Amritsar, 1908.

the founder of the Poona Sarvajanik Sabha, who ultimately rose to be a judge of the Bombay High Court, founded the National Social Conference, intended to bring together reform societies from across the country. In the south, Virasalingam (1848–1919) founded the Rajahmundri Social Reform Association in 1887, while a Hindu Social Reform Association was established in Madras in 1892. In 1905, Ranade's younger colleague and disciple G. K. Gokhale founded the Servants of India Society, modelled at once on the organization of the Jesuits and of Hindu ascetics, to create a core of dedicated activists to foster education and the uplift of girls and the depressed classes.

By the final decades of the century, non-Brahmans in Maharashtra and Madras were beginning to press the issue of their participation in public life in the face of Brahman domination. An urban-educated member of the *mali* caste (traditionally gardeners by occupation), Jyotiba Phule (1827–90) founded the Satyashodhak Samaj (1873) to challenge both the ritual and the worldly dominance of the Brahman; support for him came primarily from the prosperous Maratha castes, backed by the Maharaja of Kolhapur. In Madras, non-Brahmans sought more educational and employment opportunities, given the fact that although Brahmans were only some 3 per cent of the Presidency's population, they comprised 70 per cent of its university graduates. As in Maharashtra, the dominant voice in the protest was that of prospering middle-caste groups, including Vellalas, Reddis, Kammas, and Nairs. Following the lead of mid-century British scholars of the Dravidian languages, these non-Brahmans, in the emerging linear narrative of India's history, identified themselves as the original 'Dravidian' inhabitants of the south, in contrast to the 'Aryan' Brahmans who had supposedly entered from the north and set themselves up as a superior ruling elite. Although focusing on different texts and symbols, these movements were similar to other movements of caste mobility in their new forms of organization, their claims on social status, and their behavioural reform.

One of the most successful socioreligious reform movements was the Arya Samaj, founded in 1875 by Swami Dayanand Saraswati (1824–83). His teaching proved most persuasive not in his native Gujarat but in the north, in the United Provinces and Punjab. The Samaj shared the larger reform agenda related to women – opposition to child marriage, support of widow remarriage, and a commitment to girls' education; it allowed foreign travel; and it favoured minimizing ascriptive status based on birth. Identifying the Vedas as the central religious text, the product of a golden age that set enduring standards of behaviour and worship, the Arya Samaj opposed both idolatry and polytheism. Defiantly Hindu, Aryas participated in public debates with members of other faiths, and, stirring implausible fears that Hindus would disappear in the face of Muslim and Christian conversion, they created new rituals to convert, or purify (by a ceremony called *shuddhi*), non-Hindus and members of lower castes. Core support came from upwardly mobile trading

and professional castes (like the Khatri, Arora, and Aggarwal), who found in the reformist Arya Samaj a basis for community as well as a way to be both Hindu and 'modern' in an age of rapid change.

Radical opposition to caste, idols, and temples limited the influence of the Arya Samaj. In Bengal, many even among the Westernized class were inspired by the saintly, charismatic teaching of Shri Ramakrishna (1836–86), who did not challenge so much of conventional belief. Ramakrishna exemplified passionate devotion to God in multiple manifestations – the Divine Mother, Sita, Rama, Krishna, Muhammad, even Jesus – and inspired his followers in turn to find the divine within themselves. Ramakrishna's disciple, Narendranath Datta (1863–1902), himself a member of the Kayasth caste that had enthusiastically embraced Western education, gave up plans to study law, followed Ramakrishna, and became famous as Swami Vivekananda. He defended caste and the worship of idols, and contributed to a renewed pride in the Hindu religion by his appearance at the World Parliament of Religions at Chicago in 1893. In his subsequent preaching in America and Europe, he presented Vedantic Hinduism as a universal faith, the synthesis of all religions. Though himself a product of a Westernized colonial milieu, Vivekananda gained fame as a spokesman for the 'Spiritual East'. Inspired by the commitment to the poor of Christian missionaries, he endeavoured to evoke among Westernized Indians a sense of service to society through the social and religious activities of the Ramakrishna Mission (1897), an example that later was to inspire Gandhi.

The Ramakrishna Mission, like the reform societies, represented novel Western-inspired institutional forms, but older institutions also underwent change in this period. Learned Brahmans, backed by indigenous political authorities, had long used dharma sabhas to establish norms for moral behaviour. Now, however, although the sabhas still claimed to uphold the *sanatana* (constancy) of Sanskrit tradition, they included the new intelligentsia, were organized on British models, and more evidently accommodated change through fresh interpretations of issues related to cultural and social identity. It would therefore be incorrect to conclude that only such visibly new groups as the Brahmos and Aryas represented modern change within Hinduism. In similar fashion, alongside the better-known modernizers like Sayyid Ahmad Khan and Amir 'Ali, a range of other

Muslim movements, especially those associated with Deoband, the Ahl-i Sunnat wa'l-Jama'at of Maulana Ahmad Riza Khan Bareilvi (1856–1918), and the Ahl-i Hadith, took up reform. All religious thinkers, even those operating in the vernacular and utilizing historic institutions, of necessity responded to the challenge of Christianity and British culture as well as to the changed social and political context of the day. Whether Hindu or Muslim, those who claimed to speak for 'tradition' did so in the context of interaction with what was 'modern'. Rather than call such thinkers 'traditional', they can best be called 'traditionalist', to signal their greater continuity with the received tradition (in terms of texts, ritual, social life, and institutions) and yet, simultaneously, their self-conscious participation in the new world around them.

Bharatendu Harischandra was an influential example of a Hindu traditionalist in northern India. He typified the refusal of those engaged with Western learning and institutions to leave authority over religious matters to traditionally educated Brahmans; and he energetically used new media, especially publications – reports, editorials and letters to the editor in his journals, literary works, and translations – to shape public opinion. In so doing, he played a major role in developing modern forms of the Hindi language. He used Vaishnava devotionalism to define a coherent Hindu religion. His initial institutional base was the Kashi Dharma Sabha, founded in the 1860s by the Maharaja of Benares in response to the more radical Hindu reformist movements. Harischandra met the contemporary Christian and Orientalist critiques of Hinduism by interpreting bhakti as devotion to a single personal god, which he traced to an unbroken tradition, and he insisted on the continued value of image worship.

Among Muslims, the Deoband movement of traditionally trained 'ulama, growing out of the academy established in that north Indian town in 1868, represented a similar strategy for reform. The Deobandi seminary (or *madrasa*) taught classical Islamic texts. But the school utilized the formal classroom pattern known from British schools, fostered Urdu as a language of prose, and forged networks of supporters through subscriptions, publications, and an annual meeting. In contrast to rationalists like Sayyid Ahmad Khan, Deobandis cherished the sufi tradition of personal relations to holy men, devotional exercises, and belief in charisma. As Vasudha

Dalmia has argued in relation to Hinduism, the traditionalist organizations and teachings were to prove the more enduring. However much they were responding to the changed conditions of their day, these reformers succeeded by drawing on symbols and language familiar from their historic traditions.

Hindu and Muslim movements also shared a focus on devotional theism and the identification of personal models for emulation and worship. Both Harischandra and Bankimchandra in Bengal celebrated Krishna, particularly the Krishna of the epics, as an ideal man committed to action. Such arguments strikingly parallel those of the Punjabi Muslim poet and philosopher Muhammad Iqbal (1876–1938), who similarly celebrated historic models of action in contrast to an inward-looking spiritualism that romanticized ‘the East’ while scorning its worldly achievements. Indeed, the larger nineteenth-century Muslim focus on hadith, coupled with biographic writings like those of Shibli Nu‘mani (1857–1914), similarly exalted Muhammad as object of devotion and ideal man. Although limited to a small, upwardly mobile following among Muslims, mostly in Punjab and the United Provinces, the teachings of Mirza Ghulam Ahmad (c. 1839–1908), which identified him as simultaneously Muhammad, Krishna, and Jesus, exemplify in extreme form the late nineteenth-century turn to devotion directed towards an ideal role model. Newly available lithographs, above all those pioneered by the painter Ravi Varma, influenced by Western figurative painting and photography, often rendered the gods more human. As such, the gods were not only objects of devotion, but as ideal models worthy of emulation, encouraged strategies of self-improvement (plate 5.5). The lithographs were widely reproduced, and often used (see plate 5.8 below) on advertisements and calendars.

WOMEN AND GENDER

Many movements of the later nineteenth century gave a central place to teachings related to women, seen as a particularly potent symbol of the proper moral order. The issues at stake included female literacy, the age of marriage (which particularly affected girls since they were married younger), the opportunity of widows to remarry, and, in the case of Muslims, the practice of polygamy. In addition,

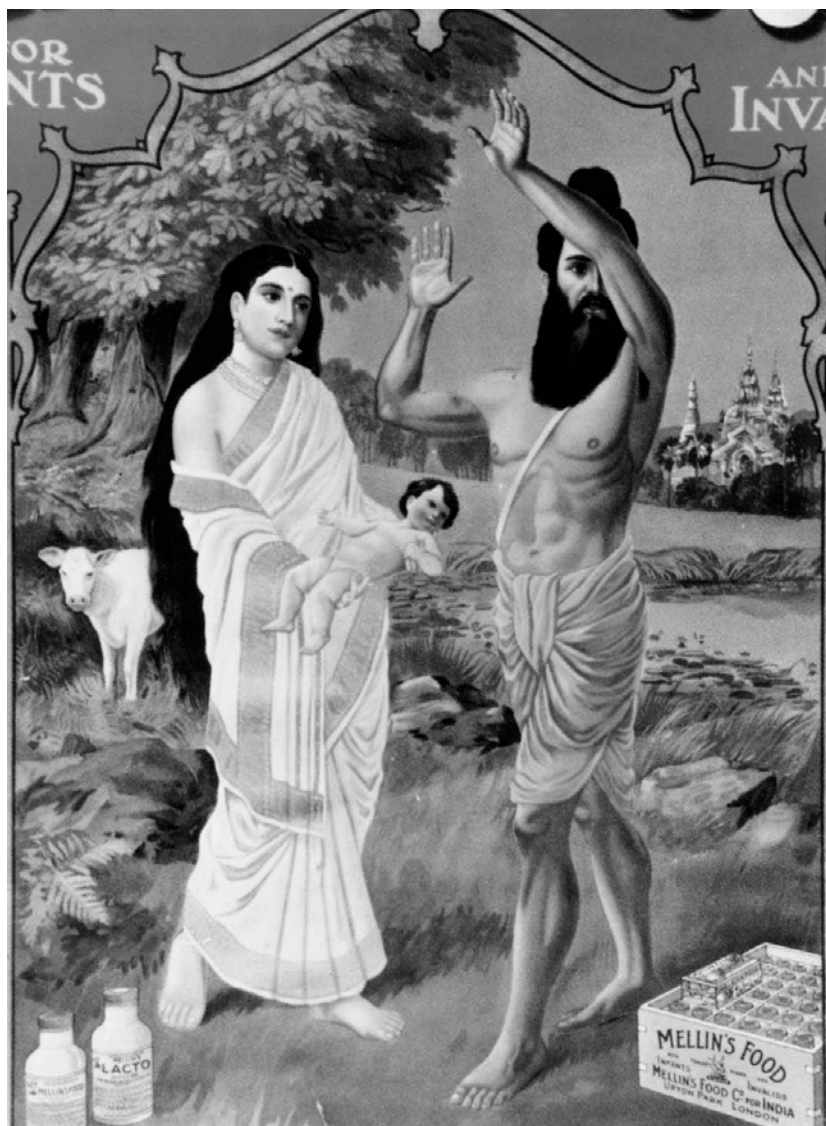


Plate 5.5 *Birth of Shakuntala*, painting by Ravi Varma, incorporated in an advertising poster for baby food.

reformers often argued in favour of simpler, less extravagant observance of weddings and other life-cycle ceremonies. These concerns cut across religious groups and engaged not only Hindus but Muslims, Sikhs, Parsis, and Indian Christians as well. This was not

surprising given that the British had long made the position and treatment of women central to their criticisms of Indian society. A further similarity across religious lines was the new role of the Western-educated 'lay' population in claiming authority to address such issues, previously the sole purview of those educated in sacred texts or sustained by lineage status.

Among Muslims, the case of the Deobandis is suggestive of how a new concern for female behaviour extended beyond the Western-educated and those familiar with English. The influential volume *Bihishti Zewar*, written in Urdu by Maulana Ashraf 'Ali Thanawi, a Deobandi reformer at the turn of the century, illustrates how a thinker both worked within a separate Muslim tradition and yet was shaped by the colonial context. Intended as a guide for young girls, the work provides a primer for literacy, enough detailed material on ritual and social norms to make – as it says – the female reader the equivalent 'of a middling 'alim' (religious scholar), models of virtuous behaviour drawn from the lives of women of the classical age and the Prophet himself, and teachings on rigorous spiritual and moral discipline. It also includes suggestions for how widows could generate income sufficient to maintain their independence, advice on how to handle new challenges like the post office and rail travel, and detailed instructions on bookkeeping and household management. The book denounces women's folk medicine, customary celebrations, and traditional forms of female sociability. Women were meant to be literate and educated, but within precise limits; and they were meant to be primarily in their homes and under their husbands' control.

A new ideal of female domesticity, across religious lines, also took shape during the decades at the turn of the century. In that ideal, women were meant to be educated and 'respectable' according to the models of behaviour set out by government and missionary example; but, in dramatic contrast to those models, they were meant also to be upholders of their sacred religious traditions. In addition, they were conceived of as bulwarks protecting what was seen as the 'uncolonized' space of the home against an outside world dominated by colonial values. In Bengal, that woman was the *grihalakshmi*, or goddess of the home. These issues explain why a sensational murder case in Bengal in 1873 drew such intense attention. The event produced not only extensive journalistic accounts, but some



Plate 5.6 *The First Blow*, Kalighat painting, Calcutta, c. 1880, by Nirbaran Chandra Ghosh.

nineteen plays as well as countless artistic depictions, including the Kalighat drawing reproduced as [plate 5.6](#). The Kalighat paintings, named for an important Calcutta pilgrimage site, transformed the English drawings and watercolours they took as models to produce

vibrant, elegant figures of the gods for a pilgrim market. By the mid nineteenth century, these paintings had begun to satirize the new middle class, not least in terms of their gender relations. In the celebrated 1873 case, the head-priest at the temple in a village outside Calcutta had seduced one Elokeshi on the pretext of giving her fertility medication. Her husband, Nabin, employed in Calcutta, learned of the affair and beheaded his wife in rage. Elokeshi's life, and death, summed up the problem of women in public – in this case at the temple (an increasingly suspect site for respectable women), but even more for women engaging in new forms of public behaviour like education outside the home. Such behaviour risked violation of the sacred space of the household and the proper, sacrificial behaviour of women. Nabin, marked by his umbrella and handbag, was the colonial subject, based in the colonial city, absent from his protective role in the household (even while he was a typically male figure of sympathy). The violated figure of Elokeshi, in Swati Chattopadhyay's argument, stood for nothing less than 'the violated social fabric of Bengali society and, in extension, the nation'. In a similar fashion, some decades later, Tagore's well-known novel *Ghare Baire* (The Home and the World) demonstrates the tragic fate of the woman who defies the sanctified domestic role. Far from mere imitation of European models, the new domesticity offered women new skills and new learning even while it provided new constraints.

The 'new' women themselves soon began to play a role as writers and advocates of reform. One outspoken woman princely ruler, the Begum of Bhopal, covered from head to foot in the garment known as a *burqa*, travelled widely to encourage education of girls. Pandita Ramabai (1858–1922), rigorously educated in Sanskrit classics, travelled throughout India to advocate women's education and social reform and wrote tracts in support of her views. Widowed at age twenty-five, she travelled to England to learn English and pursue medical studies, and became a convert to a Christianity she interpreted on her own terms. In 1888, she founded a home school for widows in Bombay, followed by another in Poona. A Deccani Brahman woman, Gangabai, founded one of the most successful female institutions, the Mahakali Pathshala ('Great Kali School') in Calcutta in 1893, intended to inculcate Hindu religious and moral principles; the school had the patronage of a wealthy landlord,

the Maharaja of Darbhanga. A Bengali Muslim, Begum Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain (1880–1932), set up schools for girls, denounced extreme seclusion, and wrote extensively, including a brilliant satire, *Sultana's Dream* (1905), in which the roles of men and women were reversed. In that imagined world, 'Women's intellects, untrammelled, devised such improvements as solar heat and air-machines; the population fully satisfied, there was no question of war; and men were kept in the zenana.'

The new norms of female behaviour helped draw new lines of social identity. One was that between the more and the less privileged. The opening lines of the popular Urdu novel *Mir'atu'l-'Arus* (The Bride's Mirror) of 1869 by Deputy Nazir Ahmad (1833–1912) set the tone, as a senior woman impatiently calls the recalcitrant daughter, Akbari, to come in from the street. The girl's association with servants and the low-born is seen as a synecdoche for her general resistance to model behaviour. Akbari, like a similar daughter in a family influenced by the Brahmos or the Arya Samaj, was meant to behave differently from the lower classes. But if social and religious reform drew class lines, even more insistently did it draw lines between religious groups. Akbari was also meant to be a Muslim – as the targets of other teachings were meant to be Hindu. There is a sad irony in that movements at root so similar enhanced community separation.

The various reform movements, then, were broadly alike in offering an opportunity for individual choice. They typically emphasized a particular sacred text, and argued for the historic continuity of their interpretations. They often presented an ideal god or figure for devotion and emulation. They sought to assimilate women to what were seen as normative and scriptural instead of folk practices and beliefs. The reform movements freed followers from local, often rural customs that tied together affinity groups and bound people to specific dates and times. In so doing they ideally suited the needs of the newly mobile classes who participated in the professions, in trade, in government service, and in business. In the process, however, boundaries were drawn, between religions and between classes; and these, embedded in everyday life and sociality, existed in tension with the individualistic ideals of the nation-state. This tension is clear in the mapping of the image of the ideal woman on to

the image of the community. The woman was made to represent at once language (the goddess Tamiltai in Tamilnadu; the Hindi 'Queen Nagri' in contrast to the strumpet, Begum Urdu), region (Bengal as Mother), and India itself as the Mother Goddess (Bharat Mata). Always, imagining the community entailed imagining an excluded other.

THE DECADE OF THE NINETIES: COMMUNALISM AND CALAMITIES

The boundaries between religions, especially that between Hindus and Muslims, became dramatically apparent in the last decade of the century. Even the teachings of the gentle Vivekananda mixed patriotism with a cult of manly virtue and evocations of Hindu glory. The Bengali novels of Bankim created a mythic 'history' in which brave Hindus triumphed over oppressive Muslim tyrants. Muslim writers turned to history too, both as apologetics, to counter Orientalist critiques of Muslim 'jihad' and 'perfidy', and as a way to foster community pride and self-esteem. Altaf Husain Hali's epic poem, the 'Musaddas' (1879), lamented the political decline of the day in contrast to Muslim glories in the past; the romantic novels of 'Abdu'l-Halim Sharar (1860-1926), like the poetry of Iqbal, celebrated Muslim rule in Sicily and Spain, when Muslims, not Christians, ruled in southern Europe. This celebration of the past was particularly marked in Maharashtra, where the old Maratha chronicles offered up heroic exploits from the days of Shivaji.

Central to this endeavour was the great nationalist Bal Gangadhar Tilak (1844-1920). A Chitpavan Brahman like Gokhale, with whom he initially collaborated, Tilak adopted an increasingly radical position celebrating the Hindu nation and opposing colonial rule. His famous motto was 'swaraj [self-rule] is my birthright and I will have it.' Through processions, celebrations, and his Marathi newspaper, *Kesari*, Tilak offered a powerful critique of the government's actions. One of the first was his challenge to the Age of Consent Bill, proposed in 1891 to raise the age limit of statutory rape in marriage from ten to twelve years. Long an issue with social reformers, the age of consent, he argued, was not a matter for the English but for Hindus themselves to decide.



Plate 5.7 Procession in Ganapati festival, Dhar, western India, 1913.

In 1893, Tilak took up celebration of the birth of the popular elephant-headed god, Ganesh (or Ganapati), Shiva's son. In so doing he turned what had been a congeries of annual family ceremonies into a grand public event. The celebration included several days of processions, music, and food, organized through subscriptions by neighbourhood, caste, or occupation. Groups of boys, often students, drilled and provided music, not only to praise Ganesh but also to celebrate Hindu and national glory, and to address topical political issues. In the early years, for instance, the festival organizers

urged temperance and patronage of *swadeshi* ('own country', or locally made) goods. At the same time they called on Hindus to protect cows and to boycott the Muharram celebrations organized by Shi'a Muslims to commemorate the seventh-century martyrdom of Imam Husain and his followers, in which Hindus had formerly often participated.

Tilak sought to use events like the Ganapati festival to build a national spirit beyond the circles of the educated elites and to demonstrate to the British the unity of Hindu society (and hence the error of the alleged government partiality for Muslims). A photograph of the festival in one of the regional towns (plate 5.7) shows the assembled crowds, the armed police ready for the ever-potential violence generated by the events, and the central role of Maharashtrian Brahmans, wearing their distinctive flat headgear, and mounted on elephants. In 1895 Tilak inaugurated a second annual festival, this time in honour of Shivaji, the Maratha ruler who, as we have seen in chapter 1, defied Mughal power and, in one famous incident, treacherously killed a Muslim noble with a concealed weapon. All of this historical reconstruction was meant as a way of opposing colonial rule, but, in the context of colonial institutions, with their sociology of difference, it also exacerbated Hindu-Muslim ill-will.

The issue of cow protection moved the perceived difference of Hindu from Muslim into the realm of popular agitation. Concern for the well-being of cows, initially taken up by the Sikh Kuka (Namdhari) sect in the Punjab as early as the 1860s, spread to the Arya Samaj under Dayananda, who urged Hindus to protest 'cow slaughter' by petitioning government on the issue. In 1893 the Arya Samaj split over the linked issues of vegetarianism and cow protection. Cow protection societies, *Gaurakhshini Sabhas*, were formed during the 1880s. The cow was a powerful symbol, embodying images of maternity and fertility, and newly salient with the renewed devotion to the cowherd god Krishna. Cow protection was embraced by the upwardly mobile, seeking to identify with higher-caste practices that included a repudiation of meat-eating. It also served as an opportunity for reformers to assert their credibility against 'orthodox' critics. Support, particularly on the part of the Western-educated, was often articulated by the argument that cattle slaughter contributed to the physical and moral weakness of

the nation by eliminating a continuing source of dairy products. It thus reflected the larger anxiety at this time over perceived national degeneracy (like the contemporaneous issue of 'neurasthenia' and such maladies in Europe) that found expression in cults devoted to body-building. Indians were determined to demonstrate to the British that they could be strong even though they did not eat beef. The intensity of the discussion in 1892-3 owed much as well to the Age of Consent Bill and the resulting determination to protect indigenous customs from British interference. Thus the movement drew on many currents, and was not, at the outset, driven primarily by the antagonism against Muslims which fuelled its later stages.

The cow societies prepared petitions, took out processions, and even acted out dramas on the issue. Cow protectors filed suits against butchers, who were typically Muslim, and tried to intercept cattle *en route* to cattle fairs, butchers shops, or destined for sacrifice in the annual Muslim 'Idu'l-Azha celebration (commemorating Abraham's sacrifice of an animal in place of his son). They also supported cattle breeding and the care of sick and aged animals. Their appeal reached far into the population, as they levied support at the level of the household for donations of grain, and even created a shadow government with courts to punish offences among Hindus. Communal riots were triggered in 1893 by the belief that local officials were not adhering to a judicial ruling – in fact not upheld by the courts – identifying cattle as religiously protected objects. This legal controversy, with the accompanying newspaper and pamphlet debates, illustrates how far the colonial idiom of legal rights and legislative entitlements had become part of everyday language and thinking. The complex of cow-related activities became part of a shared experience that defined what was taken as the moral community of the nation. Beef was, in fact, not particularly valued as food by Muslims, and its use was associated primarily with the poor. Nor were cattle needed for sacrifice, since goats readily served that purpose. Muslims nevertheless increasingly felt compelled to insist upon the rights provided them by formal law on this issue, lest the Hindu majority also circumscribe other of their practices. The debate, though focused on the cow, engaged far larger concerns.

The 1893 Hindu-Muslim riots left more than 100 people dead in western India, the North-Western Provinces and Oudh, Bihar,

and even in Rangoon, Burma. The spread of riots to such far-flung places brings home the power of the telegraph and newspapers to disseminate news that then in turn sparked further disturbances. The riots died down as it became apparent that there would be no major changes in the rules over killing animals. They left a long legacy of memories, however. The fact that many individual members of Congress supported cow protection contributed further to the view of most Muslim leaders that their interests were best served by organizations that focused exclusively on Muslim interests. For some Hindu nationalists, the behaviour of the cow activists evoked a sense of pride, for it challenged the enduring image of Hindu passivity and inaction.

Two natural calamities in the nineties produced further direct action. One was a failure of the monsoon in 1896 and again in 1899, followed by famine, particularly in the Deccan, where cash cropping contributed to agrarian instability, and adherence to free trade principles compromised the delivery of necessary aid. Desperate rural people in some cases refused to pay land taxes, often explicitly justifying their actions in terms of legal rights. The second calamity was that of bubonic plague, which entered India through the port of Bombay at the end of the decade. Invasive British anti-plague measures, which, ironically, may have helped spread the plague by dispersing people, met widespread resistance. In 1897, Damodar Chapekar along with his brother Balkrishna, who had organized a paramilitary club to march in Ganapati processions and take direct action against social reformers, assassinated Walter Rand, the Plague Commissioner, along with a second British official, as they departed from the governor's celebrations of Victoria's jubilee. Tilak, whose publications on the occasion were regarded as provocative and who almost surely concealed the identities of the perpetrators, was convicted of sedition and spent eight months in prison.

The nineties was a decade of extreme suffering, poorly handled by administrative action. Famine and plague were accompanied by what nationalists saw as wasteful military adventures, including extension of British control into easternmost Assam and Manipur in the interests of the British tea planters, and into Kalat and Chitral, producing tribal discontent and continuing military build-up, on the north-west frontier. In 1894, in a further attempt to enhance

revenues, the government levied a tariff on imported cotton goods, only to be immediately required to offset this measure of protection by a countervailing excise of an equivalent 5 per cent placed on indigenous goods. This excise was a dramatic symbol of the imperial government's concern for the interests of British manufacturers at the cost of Indian industry. Despite the provisions of the new Famine Code and the ability to move grain via rail, many peasants, increasingly dependent on cash and imported food, faced desperate conditions. The toll of depression, famine, and plague was evident in the absolute decline in population in the 1890s in contrast to the steady growth evident earlier in the century.

LORD CURZON AND THE PARTITION OF BENGAL

George Nathaniel Curzon arrived in India in 1899, convinced that efficient administration by benevolent autocratic rulers best served the country. He worked incessantly, and he was eloquent, effective, overbearing, and arrogant. He stabilized the troubled north-west by the use of tribal levies, creating a separate Muslim majority province of the North-West Frontier Province (renaming the North-Western Provinces and Oudh as the United Provinces to avoid confusion). He initiated a mission into Tibet (which culminated in its recognition as an autonomous region within China). Within India, he fought to streamline a bloated bureaucracy. He established a separate police service, attempted to rationalize land assessments, created a department of commerce and industry, supported agricultural research, and established the Archeological Survey of India to study and protect historic monuments. He especially cherished the Taj Mahal, which he embellished with an ornate light fixture over the central tomb. Curzon's style was clear in his appointment of a commission to study the problems of university education: not a single Indian was included. The 1904 Universities Act, which appeared to enhance government control over higher education, was resented and criticized by Gokhale and others of the educated elite. The public outcry should have been a clear sign that administrative efficiency alone would not, as Curzon imagined, keep the masses content and the politically active chastened. All this was to become even more clear in the partition of Bengal, announced in 1905.

Bengal had long been regarded as too large a province to govern efficiently. Curzon therefore united the eastern regions of Bengal with Assam, forming a new province of some 31 million, leaving almost 50 million to a second province in the west that included half of Bengal with Bihar and Orissa. Even with this reorganization each province was still larger than many major nations. Splitting the province in this fashion, however, made Muslims the majority community in eastern Bengal, while non-Bengalis (Biharis and Oriyas) formed the majority in the west. To the English-educated Bengali middle class this was a vivisection of their beloved homeland and a blatant attempt to reduce their power. To oppose the partition they organized a campaign of swadeshi, encouraging use of local products and a boycott of British imports. The movement was led by Surendranath Banerjea and other moderates, but small groups committed to terrorist activity also began to mobilize under its banner. Participation in the movement made clear, as the historian Sumit Sarkar has argued, that political leadership in Bengal was provided by the male Hindu bhadralok and rentier classes. The movement itself thus reinforced, inasmuch as the peasant class was primarily Muslim, the evolving, and divisive, religious identities of 'Hindu' and 'Muslim'.

Much nationalist rhetoric in the preceding decades had made 'Bengal' a focus for loyalty, as in the celebrated novel *Anandamath*, where Bankim imagined the land as the divine Mother, whose freedom from Muslim oppression would be secured by the militancy of her sons. The song 'Bande Mataram', set to music by the celebrated literary figure Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941), became the informal anthem of the nationalist movement after 1905:

Mother, I bow to thee!
 Rich with thy hurrying streams,
 Bright with thy orchard gleams,
 Cool with thy winds of delight,
 Dark fields waving, Mother of might,
 Mother free . . .
 Who hath said thou art weak in thy lands,
 When the swords flash out in twice seventy million hands . . .
 To thee I call, Mother and Lord! . . .
 Thou art wisdom, thou art law,
 Thou our heart, our soul, our breath,

Thou the love divine, the awe
In our hearts that conquers death . . .
Every image made divine
In our temples is but thine.
Thou are Durga, Lady and Queen,
With her hands that strike and her swords of sheen,
Thou are Lakshmi lotus-throned . . .
Mother sweet, I bow to thee
Mother great and free!

Those associated with the terrorist secret societies imagined Bengal less as a beneficent mother and more as the goddess of power and destruction, Shiva's consort, Kali, to whom they dedicated their weapons. The lithographed advertisement for Kali Cigarettes (plate 5.8) links an item of new middle-class consumption to swadeshi and to an image of the power the national struggle could unleash. In this vision the cigarette, not just a 'good smoke', is political and Hindu.

Nationalists across the country took up Bengal's cause, appalled at British arrogance, contempt for public opinion, and what appeared as blatant tactics of divide and rule. Calcutta came alive with rallies, bonfires of foreign goods, petitions, newspapers, and posters. Agitation particularly spread to the Punjab and to Bombay and Poona. The Ganapati festivals in western India were revived in 1905 and, increasingly anti-British, were largely suppressed by about 1910. Curzon had regarded Congress as a spent force; instead, in what proved to be his last significant action, he gave it a cause that supplied it with new strength and new tactics of mobilizing public support.

In 1905 Curzon resigned, not over the Bengal imbroglio, but rather as the loser in a power struggle with his hand-picked commander-in-chief, Lord Kitchener. In the same year, with the Liberal electoral triumph in Britain, John Morley was appointed Secretary of State for India. An admirer of Gokhale and an architect of Irish home rule, Morley was determined to win back the loyalty of India's political moderates by a large measure of reform. Curzon's successor, Lord Minto, a Whig left in place by the new cabinet, by contrast preferred advisory councils, including the princes, at all levels, as the major component of reform, a telling indication of

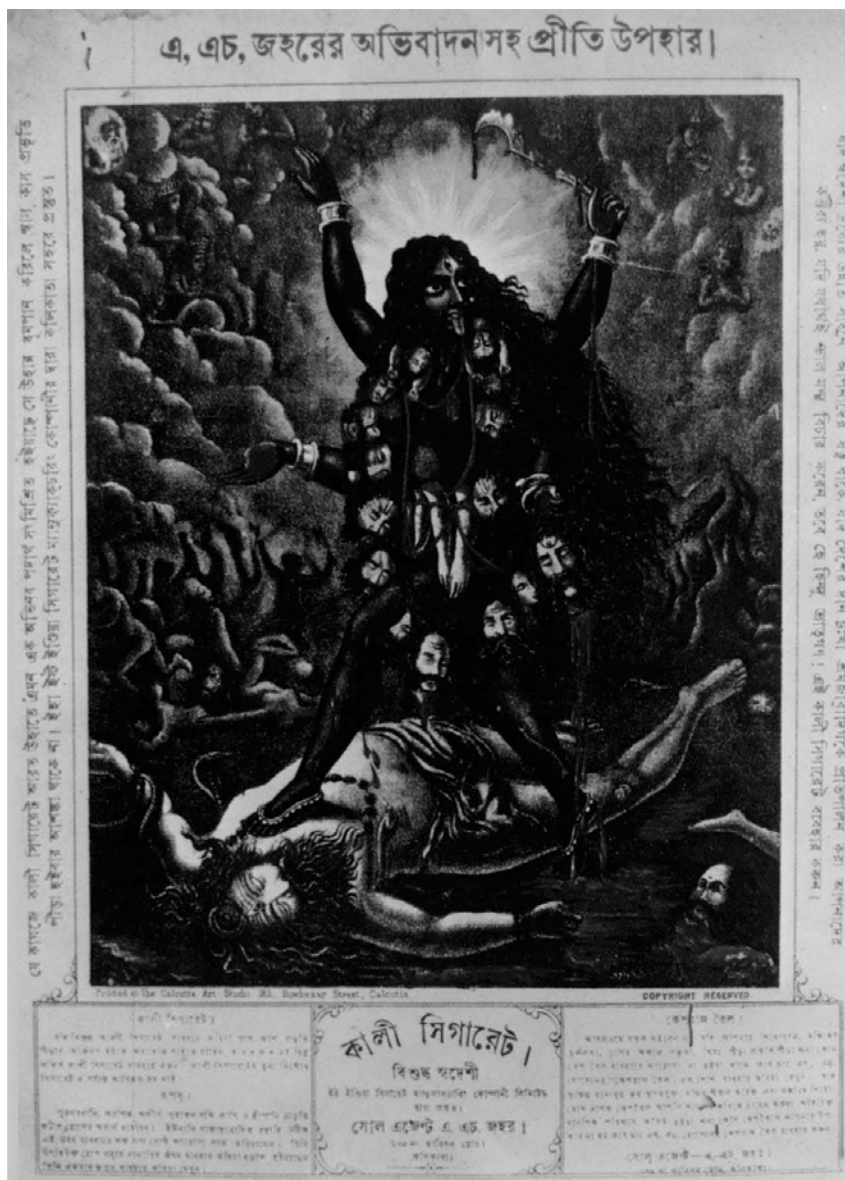


Plate 5.8 'Kali Trampling Her Consort, Siva', 1908.
Chromolithograph calendar for Kali Cigarettes of Bowbazar
Street, Calcutta.

his commitment to a continued 'durbar' style of governance. Meanwhile, against a backdrop of increased agitation, Minto turned to a heavy-handed repression. Arrests were made on the grounds of sedition; emergency orders suspended public meetings; the press was curtailed; marchers were attacked. The triumph of Japan over Russia in 1905 fired the imagination of protesters as the first-ever Asian military victory over a European power. But the harsh reality in India was evident in ever more curbs on civil liberties.

Gopal Krishna Gokhale, a 'Moderate' who had been elected Congress president in 1906, continued to press for Morley's promised constitutional reforms with the support of the Congress majority. But a strong voice within Congress, the 'Extremists' led by Tilak, now called for more radical action. This tension between Moderates and Extremists provoked a split in the Congress in 1907. That same year Tilak, charged with sedition, was sentenced to six years in prison, and transported to Mandalay. During the subsequent decade the Congress was dominated by the Moderates. Among Tilak's close colleagues was Aurobindo Ghosh (1872-1950), a Bengali educated in England. Devoted to Ramakrishna and Vivekananda, and inspired by the novels of Bankim, Ghosh reclaimed his alienated Bengali roots and joined the partition struggle. But after a period in jail for suspected terrorism; in 1910 he withdrew to the French territory of Pondicherry for a life of spiritual devotion. There his fervor and his vision of a religious nationalism drew a large following to him.

Meanwhile, the Bengal partition and the proposed reforms stimulated a Muslim reaction. Muslim leaders had not originally supported the partition. But faced with the rhetoric of 'Bande Mataram', with its implication that Bengal was a Hindu land, pressure on poor Muslims to use swadeshi cloth they could ill afford, and the riotous behaviour of the Hindu crowds, their position began to change. Muslim spokesmen turned to the new province as a way to secure a place for themselves in eastern India. British officials at the same time eagerly exploited the possibilities of a separate Muslim interest as a counterweight to the Hindu domination of the old Bengal. The small Muslim elite in East Bengal, led by Nawab 'Ali Chowdhry of Dacca (1863-1929), saw in the new province the hope of increased education, increased opportunities for employment, and, free of the

domination of Calcutta, an increased economic and political voice generally. The Bengali Muslim community increasingly drew closer in outlook to the Muslims of the upper provinces, who had come to see themselves as disadvantaged in education, employment, and political voice.

With the intervention of the English principal of the Aligarh College, a group of some thirty-five Muslims, led by the Bombay-based Isma'ili leader, the Aga Khan (1877–1957), secured an audience with Minto in the autumn of 1906. They urged the viceroy in the proposed constitutional reforms to grant Muslims a representation that would reflect not only their numerical strength, but also their political importance. They argued that Muslims 'are a distinct community with additional interests . . . which are not shared by other communities and these . . . have not been adequately represented'. In Minto, these arguments, first honed by Sayyid Ahmad Khan, found a receptive audience. 'I am firmly convinced,' the viceroy replied, 'as I believe you to be, that any electoral representation in India would be doomed to mischievous failure which aimed at granting a personal enfranchisement regardless of the beliefs and traditions of the communities composing the population of this continent.' Imperial and upper-class Muslim interests here converged in the assumption that India consisted of discrete communities, each of whom deserved representation as a community.

The Indian Councils Act of 1909, known as the Morley–Minto Reforms, did not empower the legislature to control the executive, still firmly in British hands, nor did it overturn the consultative 'darbar' model of government. It did, however, create non-official Indian majorities in the provincial legislatures (though not at the centre), and the principle of election was established at all levels. These elections were primarily indirect. Various public bodies (municipal and district boards, chambers of commerce, universities, landholders, and special constituencies like tea and jute planters) chose the members of the provincial assemblies, while the provincial legislatures elected the members of the central legislative council. Members of these legislative bodies were now empowered to ask supplementary questions and table resolutions. There was, thus, a modest enlargement of the councils, and an expansion of their powers. One portentous innovation was the inauguration, for the first time in the

provincial and central legislative bodies, of separate electorates in which only Muslims could vote, and reserved seats in the councils for Muslims. This provision implied that only a Muslim could represent Muslims, or protect Muslim interests – a presumption that would shape political life in India for decades to come. In December 1906 in Dacca the All-India Moslem League was formed. At the time this organization included only a handful of landed and aristocratic elites, but it took as its objective advancing the interests of all Muslims.

In 1911 the new viceroy Lord Hardinge orchestrated the extraordinary spectacle of the imperial durbar at Delhi. On this occasion the newly crowned King-Emperor George V and his Queen presented themselves to their Indian subjects, the only visit ever paid by a ruling British monarch to India during the Raj. The extravagant pageantry, with vast camps and an amphitheatre created for the event, could not have posed a more dramatic counterpoint to Indian cries for increased self-rule. The image was that of the viceroy as Mughal emperor; and the orchestration of precedence, gift exchange, the central role accorded to the princes, and the royal appearance at the Mughal Red Fort (above, plate 1.1) were all intended to convey what the British imagined to be an appropriate style of governing India. The king-emperor announced three ‘boons’. First was the well-kept secret decision to shift the capital from Calcutta to Delhi. This site was considered more centrally located as well as more convenient to the summer capital at Simla, but the British saw in the change as well a way to associate themselves, and also their presumably loyal Muslim subjects, with a remembered Mughal glory. It was also, of course, a move away from the centre of political activism in Calcutta. The planning of the new capital, known as New Delhi, located south of the old Mughal city, was entrusted to the architects Sir Edwin Lutyens and Sir Herbert Baker. Their imperial vision of a *beaux-arts* capital focused on a vast Viceroy’s Palace would, as it happened, be realized hardly more than a decade before it was handed over to an independent democracy.

The second ‘boon’ was the revocation of the partition of Bengal, or more precisely, the redefinition of the province. Assam, Bihar, and Orissa were given separate status as provinces in their own right; the two halves of Bengal, east and west, were reunited. Finally, as the

third boon, Bengal was raised to the status of a governor's province, comparable to Madras and Bombay, an act appropriate to its size and importance. The Congress, weakened by the 1907 split and satisfied with the new reforms, abandoned agitation. The Muslim leaders, betrayed by the revocation of partition, were increasingly uncertain of their ground. The illusion of stability produced by the spectacle of the durbar would soon give way to new issues, new leaders, and new alliances.

WORLD WAR ONE, NEW GOALS, NEW ALLIANCES

In the decade following the imperial durbar, Indian political life was shaped above all by events on the international scene. Muslim opinion, stunned in 1912 by the reversal of the Bengal partition, was further alienated by Britain's unwillingness to defend the Ottoman Empire against Russia and against uprisings in Greece and the Balkans. From the end of the nineteenth century, Muslims had debated the position of the Ottoman sultan as *khalifa* of all Muslims. Support of the khalifa, like the concept of an 'Islamic world' generally, had less to do with existing institutions than with the quest for an ideal higher than Western racialism and imperialism. Loyalist spokesmen, whether Sayyid Ahmad Khan or religious leaders like Mirza Ghulam Ahmad and Maulana Ahmad Riza Khan, denied that the sultan had any worldwide spiritual authority. The cause of the Ottomans and the khalifa was instead initially taken up by a number of younger, Western-educated Muslims, among them Muhammad 'Ali (1878-1931) writing in the *Comrade*, Zafar 'Ali Khan in his *Zamindar* in Punjab, and Abu'l Kalam Azad (1887-1958), who had earlier been a member of a terrorist group in Calcutta, in his *Al-Hilal*. They were soon joined, among others, by a group of influential Lucknow 'ulama. A medical mission went out to aid Turkish troops in the Balkan war of 1912, and an organization was formed to support protection of the pilgrimage places in the Hejaz.

The call for 'pan-Islam' went hand in hand with a move away from the loyalism of the older generation to a commitment to seek an alliance with Congress. In 1912 Muhammad 'Ali's group dominated the Muslim League session in Lucknow, passing a resolution calling for self-government. British profanation of a mosque

in Kanpur in the following year led to a riot in which twenty-three were killed and dozens arrested. This incident was both a reminder of the tenuousness of the sorely frayed relations of Muslims with the government, and a demonstration of the extent to which a local affray could engage a national Muslim interest, uniting for the first time conservative loyalists with the younger radical group.

In August 1914, Britain declared war with Germany for herself and for the entire empire, including India. All parties, with perhaps surprising alacrity, proclaimed their commitment to the British cause. Even when hostilities were extended to Ottoman Turkey that November, the Muslim League extended its support. The war years, however, saw a heightening of expectations that India would now win the self-determination the Allies claimed to be fighting for. To this end, new alliances formed among moderates and radicals, Congress and the League.

India made extraordinary sacrifices for the war effort. Well over a million Indians were recruited into the army, serving in France and especially in the Middle East, with a heavy cost of lives on all fronts. The contribution of Indian revenues was also substantial, with demand going up approximately 10 to 15 per cent in each year from 1916 to 1918. External markets were disrupted. In 1918 the monsoon failed with resultant food scarcity. The price of food grains almost doubled; the price of imported goods almost tripled. The war years were a boon for some of India's key indigenous industries, particularly cotton textiles and iron and steel. But for the population as a whole, this was a period of acute distress, intensified by the spread in 1918 of the worldwide influenza pandemic.

Despite the virtual withdrawal from India of British troops, there were no terrorist activities as dramatic as those before the war, as for example the 1912 bomb attack on the viceroy Lord Hardinge as he opened the new imperial capital at Delhi. Abroad, most notable were events on the west coast of America. There, with a base of about 15,000, mostly Punjabi, immigrants, Sikh activists in the Ghadr ('Revolution') Movement sought to provoke an uprising within India. Early in the war, many Ghadr members returned to India, hoping to join conspirators in Bengal, but most were interned and the plan collapsed. The British also feared pan-Islamic conspiracy in these years. A leading Deobandi, Maulana Mahmud

al-Hasan (1851-1920) tried to establish links with Turks in the Hijaz, but was handed over to the British and interned in Malta from 1917 until 1920. Another Deobandi, Maulana 'Ubaidu'llah Sindhi (1872-1944), similarly apprehended, had gone to Afghanistan to work with Germans and Turks in the hope of fomenting unrest on the frontier. Muhammad 'Ali and his brother Shaukat 'Ali were interned from the time Turkey entered the war until its conclusion. The British responded to these presumed internal threats by extreme repressive measures, above all the Defence of India Act, March 1915, which abrogated a wide range of civil rights.

In 1915, Tilak, newly returned from Mandalay, re-entered the Indian National Congress, in part because of what seemed a new spirit of moderation on his side and in part as a result of the death in that year of both Gokhale and his Moderate colleague Pherozeshah Mehta (1845-1915). Indian politics were further revitalized by the activities of newly formed Home Rule Leagues, whose name, goals, and style were inspired by Irish nationalist agitation. The initiative came from an Englishwoman, Annie Besant (1847-1933), who had come to India as a convert to theosophy and soon became head of the Theosophical Society, based in Adyar, Madras. A religious movement, founded by the Russian Madame Blavatsky, theosophy preached a mixture of social reform, cultivation of occult practices, and celebration of ancient Hindu wisdom that predated Western civilization. The movement had considerable appeal among Western-educated Indians (including for a time Gokhale), as well as among a sprinkling of Europeans both in India and Europe. Using her theosophical followers as a core group of supporters, Besant worked through Madras and Bombay newspapers to stimulate interest in the Home Rule League's militant politics. Tilak initiated a second league, mostly based in western India. Both established discussion groups and reading rooms, disseminated not only periodicals but posters and picture cards as well, organized lecture tours, and utilized dramas and songs to spread their message. The result was an expansion in the geographic base and, to some extent, the social diversity of those committed to self-rule. Besant was interned in 1917 and by the end of the war had developed a more quietist politics.

In both 1915 and 1916 the Congress and Muslim League met jointly, first in Bombay and then in Lucknow. In Lucknow the two

resolved, in what was subsequently known as the 'Lucknow Pact', to demand elected majorities on all councils, a wider franchise, and separate electorates for Muslims, with, in addition, what was called 'weightage' in the minority provinces. This last provision worked to favour Muslims in places like the United Provinces, where they were 14 per cent of the population but were to secure 50 per cent of the seats, while disadvantaging, for example, Bengali and Punjabi Muslims whose small majorities in each province were reduced to an exact 50 per cent of the seats in Punjab and only 40 per cent in Bengal. Muhammad 'Ali Jinnah (1876-1948), who was to be the key Muslim political leader by the time of independence, participated in these negotiations. A Bombay barrister who had been strongly influenced by both Naoroji and Gohkale in London and was elected to the Legislative Council in 1910, he had also joined the Muslim League after its change to more activist leadership before the war.

In 1917, confronted with this alliance of India's major political parties, Edwin Montagu, the Liberal Secretary of State for India, announced the British Government's intention to move towards 'self-governing' institutions and ultimately 'responsible government' in India. During the last years of the war, however, two portents of change altered the way the new order was to take shape. In 1915, Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi (1868-1948) returned to his native India from South Africa, where for twenty years he had defended the interests of the Indian population. By 1917-18 he had begun using the techniques of passive resistance he had devised in South Africa to confront indigo planters in Champaran (Bihar), mill owners in Ahmedabad, and government officials in the interests of nonpayment of revenue in Kheda (also in Gujarat). Meanwhile, following the armistice in 1918, a wide range of Muslim opinion watched in anger and dismay as the victors moved to dismember Ottoman lands and deliver key areas, including the Arab holy places, to European puppet rulers. In 1919 the All-India Khilafat Committee was formed. In the harsh repression that followed the war, Gandhi, other Congress leaders, and the Khilafatists would come together in a shared moral vision that saw British perfidy in policies that denied Indians their rightful rule, exploited the poor, and created a new domain of European imperialism in the Muslim lands of the Middle East.

In one of his most celebrated poems the Punjabi philosopher and litterateur Muhammad Iqbal expressed a vision of India's plight that linked it to oppression and exploitation around the world, not only among the colonized but in Europe as well. Iqbal put into the voice of the mythical Islamic prophet Khizr a denunciation of the categories that intoxicated rulers and ruled alike – including community (*qaum*), race (*nasl*), and colour (*rang*) – as 'imaginary gods' that distracted humans from their real needs and fostered the fundamentally corrupt interests of capitalist imperialism:

Go! give my message to the working man
This is not just Khizr's message but the message of Creation.
The cunning capitalist has sucked you dry!
For ages you've had dreams – not compensation . . .
The Assassins have drugged you with hashish
And you, unwitting dotard, think it delectation.
Race, People, Church, Kingship, Civilization, Colour –
'Imperialism' has used these as sedation!
The ignorant have perished for imaginary gods;
In stupefaction spent their very animation.
Arise! Into the world's assembly a new way comes.
In East and West, your era has begun.

To escape from the entangling imperialist net, Iqbal drew, like Tagore, on the symbols of 'Asia' or the 'East', or, more often in his case, on 'Islam', to sing a vision of a just and humane society without divisions. In India, as elsewhere, however, it would be the 'imaginary gods' that prevailed.